

FERNGLEN NATIVE PLANT GARDENS NEWSLETTER

Autumn 2026

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News from Fernglen

text and photos by Kelly Hayward

Kākā are back, croaking from within the depths of Fernglen and Kauri Park's forest. Kererū are enjoying feeding on kōwhai and tūi are darting about, melodic songs from the grey warbler, riroriro are all signs spring is close.



Sharon McGaffin's talk about glow worms

There's been a lot of activity at Fernglen. At the end of July, Milford Scouts, aged between 7-9 years, and their families arrived at the gardens at dusk. Sharon provided information about night creatures, particularly glow worms and Helen set up a craft station making tea-lights. In the dark, a warm red glow from each tea-light was the only illumination as we quietly crept along tracks on a night walk. It was a cold, perfectly still night. There was an audible gasp of awe as the children rounded the corner and set eyes on the luminescence of glow worms for the first time.



Helen Rendle and children making tea-lights



Glow worms

At our August working bee we acknowledged by way of a morning tea and gift, one of our most loyal volunteers who has been part of the scenery since the early 1990s. Rosemary Bold has been an inspiration at Fernglen working bees, always finding a forgotten job waiting to be done, like cleaning signs.

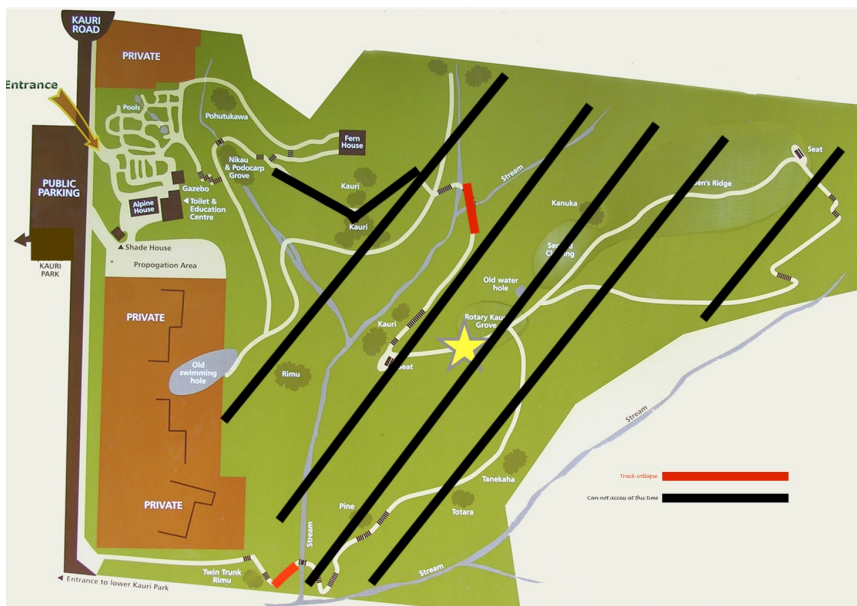


August working bee celebrating Rosemary



Rosemary with a collection of Fernglen photographs

Until recently, most afternoons, Rosemary did an afternoon walk through Fernglen tracks. That is until the boardwalk to Ben's Ridge was closed in March 2026, due to damage to part of its foundation. The reserve's lower track was closed in August last year, and we are still waiting for that repair work to commence. At this time, we have no public access to Ben's Ridge. This is devastating. We are not able to put mulch around the plant collections, weed around them or near the tracks. The fear that all the previous work carried out, over years of working bees, to have the space presentable, is being undone. To date we have no knowledge of when repair work to these tracks at Fernglen will be prioritised by the Kaipātiki Local Board. If you would like to express your concern about ongoing closure of the tracks, we urge you to please, contact Kaipātiki Local Board; kaipatikilocalboard@aucklandcouncil.govt.nz and let them know how important Fernglen Native Plant Gardens is to you.



The parts of Fernglen that are currently not accessible

Please see the sign at the end of the newsletter for spring time Botanical journaling at Fernglen. Our amazing artist Lesley is running unique classes that are enjoyed by many.

As always, your support matters.

Kind regards

Kelly

Curator Report

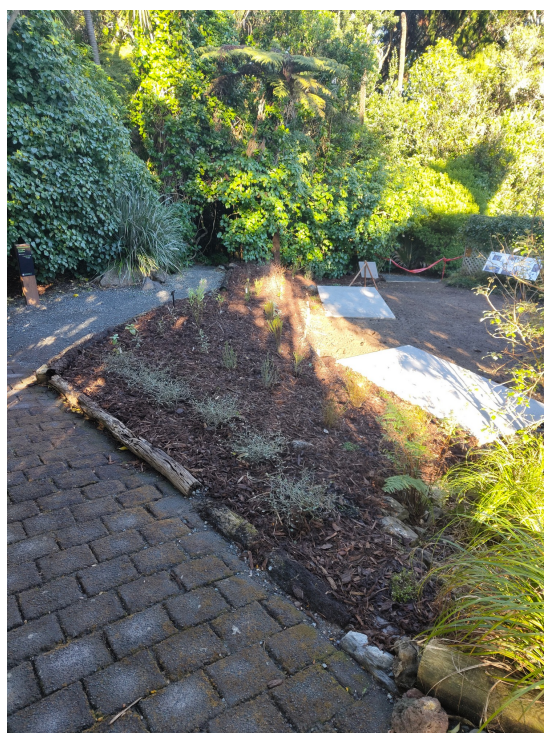
text and photos by Cameron Thomas and Kelly Hayward

Maintenance & Development

It'll be hard to miss all the changes that have been happening at Fernglen lately. The most obvious project is the new seating in the grass area. With new seats installed, new drainage put in, and grass resown this area is soon to reach its final look, with the children's educational components being the last part of this project. Along with the benches up the top, the remainder of the wooden benches by the education room have been replaced, all have been sanded and oiled giving the area a fresh new look with the same Fernglen charm. We were thankful to have had contractors who could see the vision of Fernglen and fell in love with it, despite some very cold mornings!



The new seating area



The new garden bed behind the seating area

Unfortunately, I'm still unable to give an update on the reopening of Ben's Ridge. If you have a few minutes, I would urge you to consider writing to your Local Board to express your support for reopening the tracks. While we have raised the issue with them, there is no stronger support for our case than the community making it clear that having this access matters to you too.

Planting

Our June working bee was very productive with the new garden bed near the grass area now filled with a plethora of new plants, followed up with mulching and tidy the area during the following working bee in July. I shan't scare you off with a daunting wall of botanical latin by listing the 30+

new species added to our collection so here I will just give you few of the highlights. To help section off the grass area but maintain a view from the driveway, some low-growing border plants were selected for the edge. First we have *Carpodetus serratus prostrata*, a lovely prostrate form of putaputawētā that keeps its juvenile twiggy divaricating branches and most importantly keeping its fragrant flowers accessible. Next in the border is *Corokia buddleoides*, with its standout long leaves and a fuzzy underside. Though not often found in garden centres like its plentiful related 'nativars' this is a wonderful tolerant shrub that responds well to pruning. Lastly is a line of *Plagianthus divaricatus*, or the saltmarsh ribbonwood. A vastly underappreciated native quite suitable to wetter areas which also produces wonderfully scented flowers. Along with a number of new *Carmichaelia* and *Shawia* (formally *Olearia*) this makes for our most diverse planting yet.



Preparing the ground during June working bee



Nev surveying the morning's work

A small planting was done in the rotary grove with a couple of our more "dangerous" species. As much as I'd like to display them in the main gardens a trade off had to be made for public safety, so the Rotary Grove was chosen to be more out of the way but still on display to the public. One of the plants is *Urtica australis*, the southern nettle or onga, is one of our native stinging nettles, and a very important food source for our native admiral butterflies. The other, *Coraria arborea* also known as tutu, is often touted as the poster child for poisonous native plants, with the flower petals and juice of the fruit being the only parts without the toxin tutin.

Visitors

The closed tracks has definitely kept a lot of our visitors away. We have unfortunately had some unwanted visitors as well, with attempted break-in and plant thefts, including our much beloved Marlborough Rock Daisy, which was one of Muriel Fisher's favorites. While we look into preventative measures for the future, I would ask you, please do keep an eye out for our plants. If you see something suspicious please report it to the police, the only person who should be moving

whole plants around the gardens is me, and you're unlikely to miss me doing so in the fluorescent orange shirt.

Flowering/Fruiting

I'm sure I'm not the only one noticing the effects of our odd winter so far on the plants, spring flowerers out in bud and deciduous tree starting on new leaves before they've even shed the last ones. Kawakawa has been the most obvious confused plant here at Fernglen, bringing out its flower spikes in May instead of the typical August/September. With the kōtukutuku (*Fuchsia excorticata*) we have trees that are half bare, half smothered by fresh leaves and flowers. One plant actually sticking to the calendar is *Pittosporum pimeleoides*, a quaint little shrub with delicate yellow-white flowers. Though the two plants located in the main gardens have all finished up, a recently planted cutting in the alpine house is still closing out the season.



Kawakawa flowers (*Piper excelsum*)



Pittosporum pimeleoides

A delightful early surprise has shown up on one of our recently planted kākābeak (*Clianthus puniceus*). Named for the similar hooked shape to the kākā's beak, this flower is probably considered one of New Zealand's showiest flowers. Looking just a tiny bit obscene with the full-frontal photo, it's interesting to note that the top petal (the banner) only lifts up when the flower is ready to be pollinated. The white flowered kākābeak by the ngaio is teeming with flower spikes currently so I expect quite the stupendous show from it over the next month or two.



Kakabeak buds (*Clianthus puniceus*)

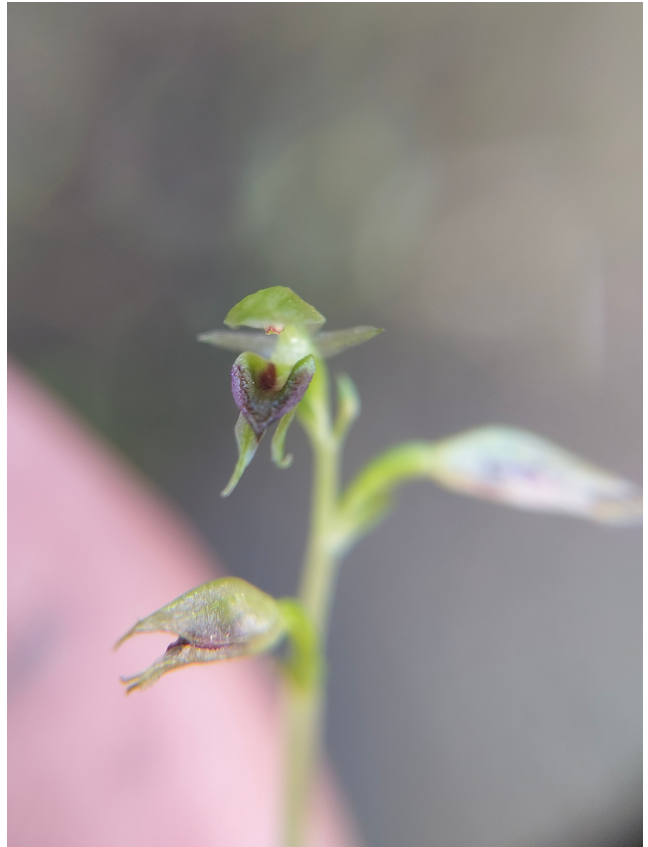


Kakabeak flower (*Clianthus puniceus*)

One last flower you most certainly would have overlooked is one of our native orchids coming up early. *Acianthus sinclarii*, the pixie cap or heart-leaf orchid, can be found pretty commonly along the ridgeline track where it hangs out with our other native kauri greenhood orchid, *Pterostylis agathicola*. Though I could not find details on its pollinator species, related species typically rely on fungus gnats for pollination which explains the tiny diminutive flowers. In the hand lens photo you can just make out its distinctive maroon lower petal (labellum).



Acianthus sinclarii



Acianthus sinclarii through a hand lens

A Look Back at an Earlier Newsletter

by Neville Arbury

Recently, when having a clean out of old papers, I came across the summer newsletter for 2003, the article I wrote titled "The Year of the Pōhutukawa". For many years I have endeavoured to record the "performance" of Auckland's pōhutukawa and where possible to provide the reason for heavy or shy flowering.

This particular year (2003) was a "stand out year" in terms of flowering, longevity and quantity/quality of flowers! Some of my "monitor trees", i.e. trees that I carefully observe every year, were bursting with flower in the first week of December and still carrying significant displays of flowers into the second week of January! Throughout this period, friends and acquaintances, almost daily, were contacting me with the same message "have you seen the pōhutukawa flowering this year?!" Unfortunately, as I wrote in 2003 I could offer no definitive reason for such brilliant flowering. There were no significant climatic factors in the previous winter or early spring. Possible only the pōhutukawa knows and is not telling.

A Walk Through Trounson Kauri Park, a Hidden Gem in Northland

by Neville Arbury

Four kilometres north of Dargaville on the way to the Waipoua Kauri Forest, just off the main road, is the remarkable Trounson Kauri Park. This 586-hectare reserve with many impressive kauri, was gifted to the Crown by James Trounson, an early settler and sawmiller. It was officially opened in 1921. Years later the reserve was designated as DOC's first "mainland island" in Northland.

Today there is a boardwalk throughout the park. A 1.6 k loop track taking around 45 minutes to complete the walk. Apart from the numerous very old kauri, there are rimu, tōtara , kohekohe, makamaka, kōwhai, pigeonwood and putaputawētā, all growing in abundance.

Ferns are also well represented at the park: Tree ferns, especially *Dicksonias*, various ground ferns and numerous "colonies" of the intriguing dwarf tree fern, *Blechnum fraseri*. We have endeavoured to cultivate this quite unique fern at Fernglen but sadly with no success.

Growing in association with the large kauri were *Astelia trinervia* (kauri grass) and *Dracophyllum latifolium*, sometimes referred to as the Dragon Tree. The *Dracophyllum* is quite unlike any other native plant, a three-metre specimen as viewed throughout the park, is an exceptionally striking sight.

Visiting in mid-march, after a wet summer, all the plants were "looking" at their very best, especially the ferns. Well worth a visit if you are travelling in this part of Northland.

Regional Variations in our Native Nīkau Palm

by Neville Arbury

With a number of our native plants, the same species growing in a different part of New Zealand, often display distinct differences in appearance. The scientific description for the regional variation is plant provenance, referring to the original location where a particular species has, over a long period, adapted to local soils and climate.

The nīkau palm is a classic example of a single species displaying variation of form while still remaining a distinct species. On the walk from the Fernery at Fernglen towards the beginning of the steep path leading to Ben's Ridge is a collection of nīkau. This area was planted by myself in the early days of Fernglen to display the different forms of nīkau found throughout New Zealand. Unfortunately, the labelling has not lasted over the years and there is some confusion as to the exact provenance of some of the specimen.

Below are listed areas of New Zealand that have quite distinct nīkau:

- **Kermadec Islands** - *Rhopalstylis bauri* var *cheesemani*, only found on Raoul Island. Very tropical in appearance and quite hardy growing in open exposed sites.
- **Great Barrier** - very robust nīkau with lush deep green fronds.
- **Paraparaumu** - Barry Hadfield Reserve, displays many very distinct tall growing nīkau.
- **Punakaiki Rocks** - just north of the Pancake Rocks are small populations of very "tropical looking" nīkau growing on the inward side of the highway, not exactly where you would expect to find nīkau but they appear to be thriving.
- **Chatham Islands** - Mainly found on Pitt Island, a quite distinct form with broader upright fronds, more tolerant to cold temperatures, resistant to drier summers and often faster growing than other nīkau.

A Stroll through Eden Gardens

by Neville Arbury

Originally a quarry in the heart of Auckland on the side of Mt Eden after being long abandoned in the late 60's and early 70's, Jack Clarke, a well-known West Auckland nursery man and a group of keen volunteers, commenced the task of creating paths, walls, planting sites and eventually planting what is now a mature tranquil garden in the heart of Auckland.

While primarily a collection of exotic trees and shrubs, especially, camellias, azaleas and rhododendrons, there is much to interest the lover of native plants, with large rimu, tōtara, rewarewa, pōhutakawa and karaka found through the gardens. Surprisingly in this volcanic environment i.e. free draining soil, tree ferns and king ferns are thriving, the king ferns are quite majestic with their large arching fronds. Nikau appear to be naturally regenerating throughout the gardens in a similar fashion to that occurring at Fernglen. Our rare native climber, *Tecomathe speciosa* found in a number of sites throughout the gardens, displaying its "trifid like" character as it advances towards surrounding plants.

It was a pleasure to visit Eden Gardens after so many years. As a young nursery man, I can clearly recall chatting with Jack Clarke and his band of aged but enthusiastic volunteers as they set about creating this absolute gem. Well worth a visit as there are also numerous activities that take place at Eden Gardens through the year.

A Recent Visit to the Adelaide Botanic Gardens

by Neville Arbury

Situated near the centre of Adelaide, a brisk walk along North Terrace or a ride on the free intercity tram, brings you to the 51 hectare gardens that are quite outstanding. A place for all to meander through while at the same time an extensive collection for those botanically minded.

Opened to the public in 1857, the gardens reflect the wisdom of early curators who planted growing trees throughout the 51 hectares, adding character and of course much enjoyed on hot summer Adelaide days.

The gardens are divided into numerous collections including: the Australian native gardens, cacti, a succulent garden, economic garden, garden of health, kitchen garden, mallee garden, Mediterranean garden and threatened plant seed orchard.

Quite intriguing is a Victorian glass house built in 1877, one of the last of its kind in the world housing a collection of rare and endangered plants from south-west Madagascar.

One of my favourite areas in the gardens is the Ficus Avenue. Here you walk between 150 year old Moreton Bay figs, all with their distinctive buttress routes.

My overall impression was one of simple amazement! The gardens were immaculately maintained and yet I saw few gardeners at work during the 5 hours of my visit. I was most impressed with the paths and signage. In particular, the paths through woodland areas were often of compressed sawdust while other areas were "paved" with compacted fine pebbles and grit.

While New Zealand plants were sighted, on making enquiries I was informed that a second botanic garden at Mt Lofty in the Adelaide hills is home to a collection of over 200 New Zealand trees and shrubs, including mature rimu and tōtara.

I will return to the gardens again when next visiting Adelaide. It was simply impossible to view all the sections in one day. My lasting memories will be of the majestic mature Australian kauris, the towering hoop pines and the many quite unique "bottle trees", *Brachychiton rupestris*.

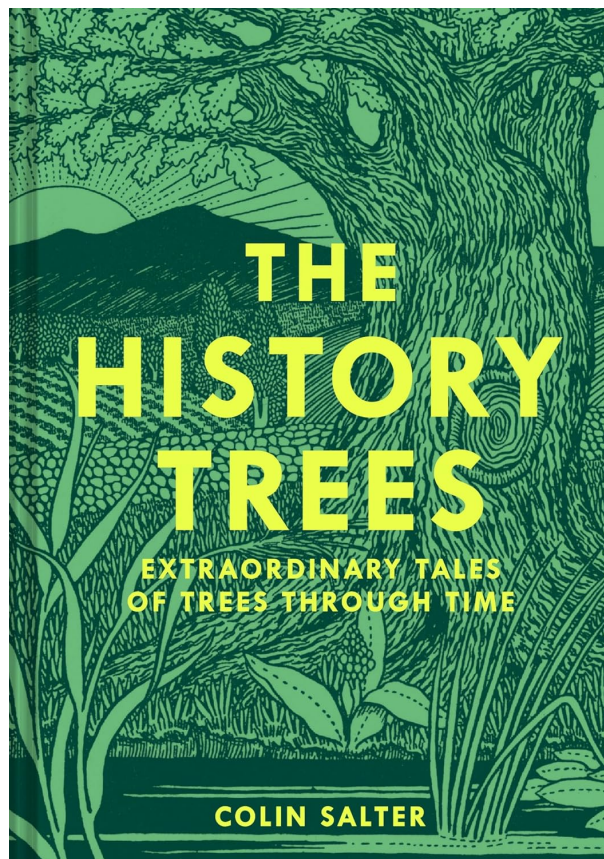
Book Review – *The History Trees: Extraordinary Tales of Trees Through Time* by Colin Salter

by Neville Arbury

From time to time, you read a book that has the wow factor! This is one of those books. Author Colin Salter takes the reader on a journey around the world highlighting some of the finest trees, their special attributes including, age, size, endangered status, historical and cultural significance. As the author writes

"There is something distinctively admirable about old trees. Old trees are like old peoples, they have lived a life, they have witnessed events and they have survived – if only they could speak what tales they could tell. Old trees command our respect."

In seventy-seven chapters Colin Salter tells the tale of so many fascinating trees. The publication is superbly illustrated and the book is a mine of information for the plant enthusiast and a fascinating read for those curious about the world's trees.



New Zealand is included in this publication, not Tāne Mahuta as could be imagined but in the chapter titled *"The Most Remote Tree in the World"*. This refers to the Sitka Spruce, *Picea sitchensis* growing on Campbell Island, New Zealand's most southerly outpost 465 kilometres south of the South Island. In the nineteenth century the island was a base for seal and whale hunting. The last people to live on the island departed in 1993 when the weather station became fully automated. The tree known as the Ranfurly Tree was named after the governor general who visited the island in the early 1910's and purportedly planted the tree. Normally the Sitka Spruce grows to a height of up to sixty metres whereas the tree on the Campbell island is multi branched and compact in form. This is possibly the result of extreme prevailing winds and staff at the weather station chopping the top of the Spruce to use as a Christmas tree. Certainly, a fascinating tale.

It is near impossible to single out the most interesting chapters as they all are descriptive of fascinating tales. Possibly the stand-out chapters are: The Avenue of Baobabs, Madagascar, The Post Office Trees in South Africa, The Burke and Wills Dig, Australia, Moon Trees, USA, Methuselah, Israel.

The story of the Moon Trees is no doubt the most unusual tale: When astronaut Stuart Roosa went into space with Apollo 14 in 1971, he took with him some seeds of sycamore, sweet gum, redwood and Douglas fir. On his return to earth trees were grown from the seeds and given to organisations and individuals around the world. This publication is an absolute must for all tree lovers, exceptionally highly recommended.

What's Happening at Fernglen?

Working bees

Regardless of the weather, working bees occur at Fernglen **on the second Saturday of every month from 9am onwards, until about 12 noon.**

The working bee is a great way to meet others, learn more about native plants, weeds and pest control. There is always a job to be done in the garden or in the education room.

No gardening experience is necessary and all ages and abilities are welcome. Gloves and gardening tools can be supplied.

Looking forward to seeing you there.

Educational tours

Are you involved with a school or an education group and would like to learn about New Zealand native plants? A unique collection of plants from all over New Zealand grows at Fernglen. To see what is on offer please contact us

on email: fernglen.nz@gmail.com

or phone: 021 236 5800

Room hire

The Fernglen Education Room is available for hire at very competitive rates. Please contact us

on email: fernglen.nz@gmail.com

or phone: 021 236 5800



Explore, Sketch and Discover

Join Lesley Alexander to observe and document the changing seasons at Fernglen

Spring

Saturday
17 October 2026
11am - 1pm



Summer

Saturday
16 January 2027
11am -1pm



Autumn

Sunday
11 April 2027
11am - 1pm



Use QR codes for more details



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